areas.[25] This has also been inferred from the inscriptions of Ashoka, a Mauryan ruler in the 3rd century BCE, whereby some 1,50,000 people were deported from Kalinga in eastern India (around present-day Odisha).[26] Separately, as a matter of transportation policy, Ashoka took great pride in planting shady trees, digging wells and building rest houses along highways.[27]

The next major direct reference to migration in ancient India appears in the second half of the first millennium CE, in the context of the migration of the *Brahmana*s during the upward march of Hindu philosophies across most parts of the subcontinent.[28] Numerous inscriptions on charters across north India inform us about land and village grants being bestowed upon this social group, most probably the priestly caste, with special taxing privileges conferred on them in their newly found colonies. Migrants moved as individuals or in entire groups, in which case their *gotra*s or ancestries were also mentioned. The source regions were varied with charters noting places such as Varendri, Sravasti, Takari, Kolanca, Hastigrama, Hastipada and Madhyadesa in north India. They moved to live under the Rashtrakutas in Maharashtra, Palas in Bengal and Bihar, Paramaras in Madhya Pradesh, but by far most went to Odisha under different ruling houses. The migrations were long distance and often in search for new homes, though the exact reasons remain a bit of a mystery. As per one legend on the Kayastha community in Bengal, traditionally a scribal or administrator caste, the five *kulin* Kayastha lineages—Bose, Ghosh, Mitra, Datta and Guha—were descendants of Kayasthas who accompanied the migration of five Brahmins from Kannauj. Since the Brahmins were invited by a local king in Bengal in the 8th century CE, this suggests one possible explanation for their movement in this period. In fact, a recent study combined genetic research with family genealogies to ascertain weak positive evidence of this migratory link between Uttar Pradesh and Bengal.[29] More generally, all combinations of migration have been noted for the Brahmanas: rural–rural, rural–urban, urban–rural and urban–urban.[30] These migrant networks potentially quickened the pace of standardizing varying Hindu practices by establishing Brahminical centres, a process greatly facilitated at that time by